



AUGUST – WINTER BEES BEGIN HERE

August is one of the most important months in the beekeeping year, even though many beekeepers are still thinking about summer. Colonies may still look large and productive, temperatures can remain warm, and late forage may still be available in some areas. However, the focus is beginning to change.

The decisions made during August often determine whether a colony survives until spring.

For many colonies, the bees emerging now will form a large part of the winter population. These bees must remain healthy for several months rather than the few weeks expected of summer workers. Because of this, August becomes less about honey production and more about preparing strong, healthy colonies for the months ahead.

WEATHER, TEMPERATURE & SEASONAL TIMING (AUGUST IN THE UK)

August often feels very similar to July, particularly during warm summers. Colonies may still be flying strongly and gathering nectar from late-season forage such as clover, balsam, heather and garden flowers.

Despite this activity, the season is changing.

Day length is already shortening and many colonies begin reducing brood production later in the month. The frantic expansion of spring and early summer is over. Colonies are becoming more focused on maintaining resources and preparing for winter.

This transition is not always obvious to the beekeeper, but the bees have already noticed it.

REALITY CHECK: August is often the month when beekeepers stop thinking about winter and the bees start preparing for it.

WHAT YOUR BEES ARE DOING

Most colonies remain populous during August, but their priorities are changing.

Worker bees continue collecting nectar and pollen where available, but colonies gradually begin shifting resources towards producing healthy winter bees and building sufficient stores.



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The queen may still be laying strongly, particularly during the first half of the month, although brood areas often begin to reduce later on.

The colony is increasingly focused on:

- Raising healthy winter bees
- Storing sufficient food reserves
- Maintaining brood quality
- Defending the hive from pests and robbers
- Preparing for declining forage availability

Healthy colonies enter autumn with purpose. Weak colonies often begin showing signs of struggle during August.

WHAT YOU SHOULD BE DOING IN AUGUST

August is a month of important decisions.

Rather than simply reacting to what you see during inspections, this is the time to assess whether each colony is genuinely prepared for autumn and winter.

Every hive should be evaluated carefully.

Ask yourself:

Is the queen performing well?

Is the brood healthy?

Are there enough bees?

Are stores sufficient?

Is varroa under control?

If the answer to any of these questions is uncertain, August is usually the best opportunity to address the issue.

PRACTICAL RULE: Strong colonies become strong winter colonies. Weak colonies rarely improve simply because you hope they will.



THE HONEY HARVEST

For many beekeepers, August is the month of the main honey harvest.

Supers may already have been removed during July, while others remain on colonies taking advantage of late flows.

Before extracting honey, ensure it is properly ripened. Honey that is not mature enough may contain excessive moisture and can ferment after extraction.

The temptation is often to remove as much honey as possible.

However, beekeeping is not simply about taking honey.

Every colony must retain enough food to remain healthy until supplementary feeding or natural forage can sustain them.

The strongest colonies often produce the largest surplus, but they can also consume substantial amounts of food if conditions deteriorate.

VARROA – THE MOST IMPORTANT AUGUST TASK

Few August tasks have a greater impact on winter survival than varroa management.

By late summer, mite populations can become surprisingly high. Even colonies that appear healthy may be carrying significant varroa burdens.

The greatest danger is not always the mites themselves.

High mite levels increase virus transmission throughout the colony. Bees raised under these conditions often have reduced lifespan and poorer winter survival.

This is why August is such a critical treatment period.

Reducing mite levels now allows winter bees to develop in a healthier environment.

REALITY CHECK: A colony can look strong in August and still fail during winter because varroa pressure was ignored.



RAISING WINTER BEES

One of the biggest misconceptions among new beekeepers is that winter preparation starts in autumn.

In reality, winter preparation begins during August.

The bees emerging now and during September are different from the workers that filled supers during summer. They are physiologically adapted to survive much longer and support the colony until spring.

Anything that compromises these bees—poor nutrition, disease, high varroa levels or failing queens—can affect winter survival.

When viewed this way, August becomes far more than a harvest month.

It becomes a colony health month.

ASSESSING QUEENS AND COLONY STRENGTH

August provides an excellent opportunity to evaluate queens honestly.

A queen that has performed poorly throughout the season is unlikely to improve during winter.

Look carefully at brood patterns, colony temperament and overall population levels.

Colonies should still contain enough bees to cover brood effectively and maintain healthy activity.

If a colony is extremely weak, queenless or struggling despite intervention, it may be better to unite it with a stronger colony rather than attempt to carry two weak units through winter.

Many successful beekeepers enter winter with fewer colonies than they had during spring.

The difference is that those colonies are strong.

FEEDING AND FOOD STORES

As forage availability begins to reduce, food reserves become increasingly important.

Some colonies may still be collecting nectar successfully, while others can become surprisingly light within a short period.

Regularly assess stores rather than making assumptions.



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A hive that felt heavy in July may require attention by late August, particularly if weather conditions deteriorate or local forage ends abruptly.

Where feeding is required, it should be planned and carried out efficiently.

The objective is not simply to provide food today.

The objective is to ensure colonies enter autumn with sufficient reserves for the months ahead.

PRACTICAL RULE: Do not judge food stores by external activity. A busy entrance does not always mean a well-provisioned colony.

WASPS, ROBBING AND HIVE DEFENCE

August often brings increased pressure from wasps and robbing bees.

Natural forage becomes less abundant, and many insects begin searching for alternative food sources.

Weak colonies are particularly vulnerable.

Signs of robbing can include frantic activity around entrances, fighting bees, and bees attempting to gain access through small cracks or gaps.

Strong colonies usually defend themselves effectively, but weaker colonies may require assistance through entrance reduction and careful management.

Good apiary hygiene becomes increasingly important.

Honey, syrup and exposed comb should never be left available unnecessarily.

HEALTH AND DISEASE MONITORING

August remains an important month for disease awareness.

Brood patterns are often easier to assess than during peak spring expansion, allowing potential problems to become more visible.

Pay attention to:

Brood quality.

Larval appearance.

Adult bee behaviour.

Signs of virus pressure.



Overall colony strength.

Any unusual findings should be investigated rather than ignored.

The earlier problems are identified, the more options remain available.

EQUIPMENT AND COMB MANAGEMENT

Once supers have been removed and extracted, attention turns towards protecting equipment.

Stored comb is valuable.

Drawn comb saves colonies enormous amounts of energy during spring, making proper storage worthwhile.

Wax moth, rodents, damp conditions and poor ventilation can all cause damage if equipment is neglected.

August is therefore a good opportunity to clean, organise and prepare equipment before autumn weather arrives.

RECORD KEEPING

The information collected during August often influences every major decision made during autumn.

Inspection notes should include:

Honey harvests.

Varroa monitoring.

Treatments applied.

Queen assessments.

Colony strength.

Food reserves.

Any concerns requiring follow-up.

These records become increasingly valuable once colonies begin reducing brood and external activity later in the year.



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AUGUST TAKEAWAY

August marks the point where successful beekeeping shifts from producing honey to producing healthy winter colonies.

The bees raised now may be responsible for carrying the colony through until spring.

Honey harvests remain important, but colony health, varroa control, queen quality and winter stores matter far more in the long term.

Colonies that enter autumn healthy, well-fed and carrying low mite levels give themselves the best possible chance of surviving winter and thriving when spring returns.

REALITY CHECK: The most important product of August is not honey. It is healthy winter bees.